



The first batch trained in Scribus at Janayugam

According to Hussain K.H., library and information scientist, the importance of this project lies in it being the first instance of the traditional Malayalam script being used fully in newspaper production. In the process, the team totally discarded the 'reformed script' that had been in use since 1970, which reduced the rich character set of traditional Malayalam.

The project adapted to the philosophy of the 'Rachana Movement' that became popular in 1999, to propagate the non-truncated script of Malayalam. Three fonts were developed for news headings, and the staff was given training in this character set from the beginning. The team had some issues like the text-scaling feature in Scribus during implementation. But quick responses from community members like Ale Rimoldi helped to solve the issues in a very short time.

Migrating from ASCII to Unicode was a challenge

There were some other challenges as well. The first issue was the migration from ASCII to Unicode. Even though Malayalam Unicode was embedded in MS Windows since 2004, most newspaper reports are still typed and mailed in ASCII format to the editor's desk. The

Alpha Fork Technologies team had to develop software to convert those files to Unicode. It also had to provide support for Pagemaker files. Software libraries to support Pagemaker files were available from the Document Liberation Project, but these didn't have proper support for Malayalam. So, the team modified the code to support Malayalam.

The biggest issue the team faced was that GIMP did not have CMYK support. There were some issues with Scribus too, but timely intervention from the community helped to solve the matter. "We had issues related to deprecated software at the printing press too, where they were using Windows XP that does not have proper support for Unicode fonts. We had to outline embedded fonts to solve this issue," says Mujeeb Rahman K.

Hardware issues

With regard to hardware, the biggest issue was with peripheral devices. Printers and scanners that were bought without considering if they had support for Linux were the problem. The team had to use unofficial drivers to make them work at least partially. In spite of all this, the transition was smooth and the current workflow is better than the conventional one, according to the Janayugam team.

FOSS: A game changer for the print media

The print media is facing a financial crunch, globally, and the move to open source, as implemented by Janayugam, can be a game changer. Due to the emergence of online media and its wide reach, print advertisement revenues have dropped and many newspapers have been forced to shut shop. The cost of the raw material necessary for the production of newspapers is on the rise, and so switching to FOSS can be very beneficial.

Thomas says, "This move did help us reduce the cost of the OS and software migration by almost one-third what it would have cost for the proprietary alternative. That the basic DTP software comes free is the most attractive option. You need not pay any subscription or licence fee for the OS or software, and not even for the periodical upgradation."

Currently, Adobe rules the printing industry and its subscription fee is hiked every year. However, for a more successful switch to FOSS, a few improvements are needed. Thomas adds that support for CYMK in GIMP is very important for printing. Also, Scribus does not have multi-thread support, which makes the system hang when dealing with a large number of page documents. If these limitations are fixed, it can become high-end professional DTP software, and become a strong contender for the proprietary software from Adobe. **END** 🐧